

Terminalia arjuna (Combretaceae)

Arjun

The bark of the arjun tree has been used in Indian herbal medicine for at least 3,000 years, and has always been valued as a remedy for the heart. The first person credited with prescribing arjun for heart disease was Vagbhata, an Indian physician of the 7th century CE. Arjun is an example of an herb for which the traditional use has been confirmed by modern pharmacological research.



Arjun is a handsome evergreen tree. Its bark is prescribed to help heart and circulation problems.

Habitat & Cultivation

Arjun is found throughout most of the Indian subcontinent, from Sri Lanka to the foothills of the Himalayas. It thrives in wet, marshy areas and on riverbanks. The tree is grown from seed and the bark is cut in late winter.

Related Species

A number of other *Terminalia* species are also used medicinally, notably beleric myrobalan and chebulic myrobalan (*T. belerica* and *T. chebula*, p. 275). Both are close relatives of arjun and are among the most used herbal medicines in India.

Key Constituents

- Tannins
- Triterpenoid saponins
- Flavonoids
- Phytosterols

Key Actions

- Cardiac tonic
- Lowers blood pressure
- Reduces cholesterol levels

Research

■ **Cardiac tonic** Research has been going on into arjun in India since the 1930s. The results have been highly conflicting, with some studies indicating that it increases heart rate and blood pressure, and others suggesting the reverse. It seems that the herb is best used to treat conditions where the blood supply to the heart is poor, for example in ischemic heart disease and angina. In a 2002 clinical trial in India, 58 men with angina were given arjun. Results were very positive, with those taking arjun experiencing a marked reduction in angina symptoms and an increased capacity to exercise.

■ **Cholesterol** Indian research has demonstrated that arjun reduces blood cholesterol levels.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Traditional heart remedy** In Indian herbal medicine, arjun has always been taken as a heart tonic. It has a long history of treating heart failure and edema (a condition in which fluid accumulates in the ankles and legs because the heart is not pumping adequately).

■ **Ayurvedic medicine** Ayurvedic physicians use arjun to restore balance when any of the 3 humors, *kapha*, *pitta*, or *vata* (see p. 37), is present in excess. As a decoction, the bark is given to treat diarrhea and dysentery. Powdered bark is part of a traditional Ayurvedic treatment for asthma. Arjun is also given in Ayurveda for bile duct problems, as well as for poisoning and scorpion stings.



Arjun

An evergreen tree reaching 100 ft (30 m), with pale yellow flowers and cone-shaped leaves.

Parts Used



Bark has constituents that lower blood pressure and reduce cholesterol levels.



Dried bark

Bark is used to treat heart disease in India

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Caution** Take only under professional supervision.



Decoction is used by herbalists to treat poor circulation to the heart.



Tincture is a valuable cardiac tonic. Herbalists prescribe it to treat angina.



Powder is a traditional Ayurvedic remedy, prescribed for asthma.

■ **Modern heart remedy** Arjun is beneficial for angina and poor coronary circulation. It is also of benefit if the heart's rate and rhythm are abnormal. By lowering blood cholesterol levels,

reducing blood pressure, and supporting normal heart function, arjun improves the health of the circulation and reduces the risk of developing a serious heart problem.